

Anil Ambani than an Atiq Ahmad (who won on a SP ticket in 2004 despite facing murder charges)," said Amar.

Regardless, Mohan Singh has asked him to vacate his Rajya Sabha seat. Amar refuses, saying that it was Mulayam who told him to keep the seat as he had earned it. According to Parliament convention, he can keep the seat even after being expelled from the party. He loses it only if he resigns. However, Amar's expulsion has created the biggest split in the party since it was formed in 1993. When others like

Akhilesh told INDIA TODAY he "would not speak against Amar uncle". However, with Mulayam as the party chief, Akhilesh as the state president, younger brother Shivpal Yadav as the leader of the legislative party and Ram Gopal Yadav as leader of the party in the Rajya Sabha, it is clear that the Yadav clan now has full control. "It looks like a Yadav Mahasabha," says Amar, who wants to emerge as a Rajput leader. His advisers say that Rajnath Singh having been cut to size there is no big Thakur leader in the state.

Mayawati has been promoting Rajput leaders in eastern Uttar Pradesh to wean the community from the SP. Amar plans to woo them away. Recently, he organised a rally in Poorvanchal asking for separate statehood. He would like to share a common platform with Mayawati on the issue of small states.

The shrewd Thakur makes up with strategy what he lacks in mass base. "There are many small, scattered and faceless MBC (Most Backward Classes) outfits. I will give them a face and unite them," he says. He has floated a socio-political outfit, the Lok Manch, and is touring the state to mobilise Thakurs and MBCs (Lodhs and Kushwahas). "Let's see if I am a rootless wonder or a wonder with roots," he says. He plans to open centres for English and computer classes in the state, beginning with one in Azamgarh. Talking technology and women's reservation, Amar is building a new persona that totally contrasts Mulayam's image.

Revelling in the media glare, Amar says, "If I knew my application for sick leave would create such a national furore, I would have refrained." But no political party has claimed him yet. As a NCP leader said, "It is difficult to accommodate someone of his stature. He will want a senior post." The Congress, too, is wary of him, despite his newfound respect for the Gandhis. With court cases pending against him, Amar knows he needs to find a political backer soon. He even had kind words for Mayawati. "I now understand why Mayawati was so bitter. When she was supporting the SP, she was nice. When she was not, the guest house incident happened. I am being treated the same way after 14 years," he said.

His biggest challenge is to refashion himself as a leader, not just a manager. As for Mulayam and family, they will use Amar's exit to win back their old socialist base and Muslim vote-bank. About his break-up with his *netaji*, Amar wrote in his blog, "*Wakht ka aakhri farmaan abhi baaki hai, meri takdir ka anjaam abhi baaki hai* (The final verdict is yet to come. My fate is still awaited.) Each will now have to face his destiny without the best friend by his side. ■

AMAR (LEFT) WITH MULAYAM, JAYA BACHCHAN AND JAYA PRADA



Beni Prasad Verma, Azam Khan or Raj Babbar walked out, they did so alone. Today, the 'rootless wonder', has the backing of at least four MLAs and the two Jayas. Even so, the number is not as large as he had claimed. One of his loyalists, Abu Azmi, now refuses to resign from the party. SP leaders now hope that Amar's exit may see the return of those who left the party by citing issues with the Thakur. They also blame him for alienating 'Maulana' Mulayam's Muslim base by first making the party vote for the pro-US nuclear deal and then by bringing in Hindutva icon Kalyan Singh.

Mulayam has already started grooming a post-Amar leadership with son Akhilesh and brother Ram Gopal Yadav emerging as the new pillars. Incidentally, even though he has spearheaded the oust-Amar campaign,

AMAR SINGH: NOW WHAT?

- Use his newly created outfit Lok Manch to woo Thakurs and 'most backward classes'.
- He has been praising Sharad Pawar, but the NCP is already well connected with corporate India.
- The Congress is an option, but the party is wary of his style and rivals like Digvijay Singh may block his entry.
- Mayawati is not likely to trust her former foe so easily.
- The BJP does not suit his secular brand of politics.